

Olympiad Test Paper — Social Science (Class 7) — Paper 4

Chapter 4: New Beginnings: Cities and States

Paper 4 — (progressively harder)

Subject	Social Science (NCERT Class 7)
Chapter	4 — New Beginnings: Cities and States
Total Questions	60 (Multiple Choice, single correct)
Maximum Marks	240
Suggested Time	90 minutes

Marking scheme: +4 for each correct answer · -1 for each wrong answer · 0 if unattempted.

Instructions: Each question has four options (A), (B), (C), (D); exactly one is correct. Classic traps: confusing the First (Harappan, copper/bronze, no coins) with the Second (Ganga-plains, iron, punch-marked silver coins) Urbanisation; assuming every mahaajanapada was a hereditary monarchy when Vajji and Malla were ganas/sanghas; reading the gana/sangha assemblies as full modern democracies; mixing up the smaller janapada with the larger mahaajanapada; and reversing the directions of the Uttaraapatha and Dakshinaapatha. Do not write on this paper — mark answers on your answer sheet.

1. A historian arranges four developments on a timeline: the first great empires, the spread of iron in the Ganga plains, the Harappan urban order, and the merging of janapadas into mahaajanapadas. Reading from earliest to latest, which is the only sequence consistent with the chapter?

- (A) The spread of iron, then the Harappan urban order, then the first empires, then janapadas merging into mahaajanapadas
- (B) Harappan urban order, then the first empires, then the spread of iron, then janapadas merging into mahaajanapadas
- (C) Harappan urban order, then the spread of iron, then janapadas merging into mahaajanapadas, then the first empires
- (D) Janapadas merging into mahaajanapadas, then the Harappan urban order, then the spread of iron, then the first empires

2. Two students debate why scholars prefer the label 'Second Urbanisation' over 'Harappan revival' for the Ganga-plains cities. Which single point most decisively settles the question in favour of 'Second Urbanisation'?

(A) The Ganga-plains cities reused the very same Harappan citadels and the same undeciphered script, simply under a new name

(B) The two waves happened only a few decades apart, so 'revival' would exaggerate the time between them

(C) The Ganga-plains wave arose centuries later in a different region with new features such as iron and coins, so it was a fresh development rather than the same people resuming the same Indus cities

(D) The Harappans themselves moved east and rebuilt their cities, which is why historians count it as a continuation

3. A teacher says, 'The collapse of the Harappan cities was a loss of urban ORDER, not just of buildings.' Which single observation, if true, would most strongly UNDERMINE that claim?

(A) Trade networks, the writing system and city administration carried on smoothly and people kept living urban lives right through the period after the cities fell

(B) After the cities fell, people largely went back to village life and large-scale trade and writing faded away

(C) It took roughly a thousand years before organised city life appeared again, this time in the Ganga plains

(D) The new cities of the Ganga plains used iron and coins that the Harappan cities had never had

4. Why does the chapter treat the agreement of two independent kinds of evidence as making a reconstruction of the Second Urbanisation more trustworthy than relying on either alone?

(A) When excavated remains and ancient written accounts point to the same picture, an error or bias in one is unlikely to be matched by the other, so the shared conclusion is more reliable

(B) Because ancient texts record the exact spoken words of ordinary people, which excavation can never recover, the texts alone are decisive

(C) Because excavation gives precise dates while texts are always wrong, so the dig settles everything and the texts merely decorate it

(D) Because the same Harappans who built the first cities also wrote the texts and dug the later sites, guaranteeing the two agree

5. The word janapada combines jana ('people') and pada ('foot'). A student says this naming captures a key historical change. Which reading best fits both the word and the chapter?

(A) It marks people who had stopped moving and settled, putting down roots in a territory they identified with

(B) It marks an army on the march, since 'foot' points to soldiers always on the move

- (C) It marks a coin stamped with a footprint, used by settled traders
- (D) It marks a sprawling empire that placed its 'foot' over many distant lands

6. A classmate argues that janapadas should NOT count as early states because they were small and clan-based. Which response best uses the chapter's own definition of a state to refute him?

- (A) He is right, because a true state must rule many regions, and janapadas were far too small to count
- (B) He is wrong, because janapadas had no leader at all and ruled themselves purely by custom, which is the mark of a state
- (C) A state needs settled people, a defined territory and an organising authority, and janapadas had all three: clans tied to a land and led by a rajaa who protected and organised it
- (D) He is wrong, because janapadas issued their own iron coins from the very start, which is what defines a state

7. Why is it a historical mistake to use 'janapada' and 'mahaajanapada' as interchangeable words?

- (A) A janapada was a coined unit of money while a mahaajanapada was a long-distance trade route
- (B) A janapada was a smaller, earlier clan territory, while a mahaajanapada was a larger state that formed as such units merged and grew, so the words name different scales and stages
- (C) A mahaajanapada came first in time and later broke apart into smaller janapadas
- (D) A janapada was always a republic while a mahaajanapada was always a monarchy

8. Of the four conditions below, which one was NOT among the reasons the chapter gives for so many mahaajanapadas clustering in the Ganga plains?

- (A) A cold, dry climate with no rivers, which let armies march freely across open ground
- (B) Fertile alluvial soil that produced food surpluses
- (C) Access to iron for tools and weapons
- (D) Rivers and trade routes that linked the region together

9. A historian cautions against treating the famous count of 'sixteen mahaajanapadas' as a perfectly fixed, official figure. Which reasoning best supports that caution while staying true to the chapter?

- (A) The real number was certainly one hundred, and the texts simply rounded it down to sixteen
- (B) Sixteen is the most-cited traditional list, but ancient texts grouped the states in their own ways, so the number reflects textual convention rather than a single exact census
- (C) The mahaajanapadas never actually existed, so any count of them is pure invention
- (D) The list was compiled by the Harappans, whose figures cannot be trusted

10. Which statement best captures what the phrase 'sixteen mahaajanapadas' actually represents in the chapter?

- (A) Sixteen empires that rose and fell one after another, each replacing the last
- (B) Sixteen small villages clustered together in a single river valley
- (C) A set of large, roughly contemporary states that between them stretched across a wide span of the Subcontinent, from the northwest to the east
- (D) Sixteen different names for one and the same kingdom

11. A capital's defences combined a rampart, a moat just outside it, and a deliberately narrow gateway. Taken together, what do these three features most strongly reveal about its rulers' priorities?

- (A) They were concerned with defending the city and controlling who and what passed in or out, as a wealthy state with rivals would need to be
- (B) They were chiefly interested in making the city beautiful for festivals and processions
- (C) They were mainly trying to store rainwater for use in the dry season
- (D) They wanted to encourage anyone at all to wander in and out as freely as possible

12. Why were the gateways in a capital's walls often kept deliberately narrow, in terms of how a fortified state actually worked?

- (A) A narrow gate let rainwater drain out of the city much faster
- (B) A narrow gate allowed two war elephants to march through side by side
- (C) A narrow gate made the wall look more graceful from a distance
- (D) A narrow gate funnelled traffic so that a small guard force could inspect and regulate everyone and everything entering or leaving

13. Rajagriha, Kaushambi and Varanasi were mahaajanapada capitals about 2,500 years ago and remain busy cities today. What is the soundest inference a historian can draw from this continuity?

- (A) Nothing about these places has changed in 2,500 years
- (B) Their locations offered lasting natural and strategic advantages that made them worth living on for millennia
- (C) They must originally have been founded by the Harappans
- (D) They could never have been fortified, since fortified cities do not last

14. A museum displays a silver punch-marked coin under a label reading 'First Urbanisation, Harappan period.' Why is this label historically wrong?

- (A) Coined money belongs to the Second Urbanisation; the Harappans of the First Urbanisation did not use coins at all
- (B) Because the Harappans used only gold coins, never silver ones
- (C) Because coins were never used anywhere in ancient India
- (D) Because genuine punch-marked coins were made of iron, not silver

- 15.** Which line of reasoning best explains why the appearance of punch-marked coins tells historians that TRADE had grown, not merely that silver was available?
- (A) Coins are a convenient common medium of exchange, so their spread shows that buying and selling had outgrown what simple barter could handle
 - (B) Coins were worn only as jewellery, so their spread shows that personal wealth had grown
 - (C) Coins were minted only to be buried with the dead, so they show that funeral customs had grown
 - (D) Coins made barter easier to carry out, so their spread shows that barter had become more popular than ever
- 16.** An expert finds a coin of Avanti far away near Gandhaara and a coin of Anga turning up near the Godavari. Which single explanation accounts for BOTH finds at once?
- (A) Each coin was made on the very spot where it was later found
 - (B) All regions of India used one single identical coin, so origin cannot be told
 - (C) Coins circulated along the trade routes, so a region's coins could end up far from where they were struck
 - (D) Coins were forbidden to leave the region that made them
- 17.** What did the chapter present as the core awkwardness of barter that coins were introduced to solve?
- (A) Barter could only be carried out after sunset, so daytime trade was impossible
 - (B) Barter required a bank in every village before any exchange could happen
 - (C) In barter each side must find a partner who has what they want AND also wants what they have, which is hard to arrange
 - (D) Barter could not work without iron tools to complete each swap
- 18.** Usually a mahaajanapada struck its own coins, yet the chapter adds an important qualification. Which statement captures it correctly?
- (A) No region ever accepted another region's coins under any circumstances
 - (B) Only the Harappans were permitted to mint coins for everyone else
 - (C) Coins from neighbouring regions were used and traded as well, and some even reached beyond India
 - (D) Coins were banned the moment they crossed outside the capital's walls
- 19.** In a monarchical mahaajanapada the office of rajaa was hereditary. What is the clearest practical consequence of describing kingship as 'hereditary'?
- (A) The assembly voted to choose a brand-new ruler whenever the throne fell vacant
 - (B) Power normally passed within the family, typically to the king's son, rather than being awarded afresh each time
 - (C) The wealthiest merchant in the city automatically became the next ruler
 - (D) Whichever foreign conqueror arrived next inherited the throne by right

20. Which of the following was NOT among a monarch's main duties as the chapter describes them?

- (A) Keeping law and order in the realm
- (B) Collecting revenue, that is, taxes
- (C) Maintaining an army and the city's fortifications
- (D) Choosing his successor by holding a public election among the people

21. Within a monarchical mahaajanapada, how is the relationship between the rajaa and the sabhaa and samiti best described?

- (A) The assemblies governed directly and the rajaa was only a powerless figurehead
- (B) The rajaa ignored the assemblies entirely, since they had no role whatsoever
- (C) The rajaa ruled but was expected to take counsel from these assemblies and his ministers rather than act purely on his own whim
- (D) The assemblies elected a fresh rajaa every single year by open vote

22. The names sabhaa and samiti first appear in the Vedas, while gana and sangha describe later political forms. What does this layering of vocabulary most reasonably suggest to a historian?

- (A) Ideas of collective counsel were old and developed over time into the assemblies and republics of the mahaajanapada age
- (B) The Vedas must have been composed after the mahaajanapadas had already ended
- (C) Assemblies were a sudden, brand-new invention with no earlier roots at all
- (D) Gana and sangha mean exactly the same thing as a hereditary king

23. In a gana or sangha such as Vajji, how did a person become rajaa, and why does this matter for classifying the state?

- (A) The eldest son of the previous rajaa always inherited the position, exactly as in a monarchy
- (B) Priests carried over from Harappan times appointed the rajaa
- (C) The assembly selected the ruler through discussion and, if needed, a vote, which is what makes the state a republic rather than a monarchy
- (D) A distant foreign empire imposed the rajaa from outside

24. A classmate insists, 'All sixteen mahaajanapadas were ruled by hereditary kings.' Which correction is most accurate?

- (A) Most were monarchies, but Vajji and Malla were ganas or sanghas where the assembly held the real decision-making power
- (B) He is entirely correct, since there were no exceptions at all
- (C) He is wrong because none of the mahaajanapadas ever had a king
- (D) He is correct, but only the southern mahaajanapadas had kings

25. Vajji and Malla are called 'early republics' yet NOT full modern democracies. In which respect were their assemblies genuinely broader than a monarchy while still narrower than a modern democracy?

- (A) Every adult, including the poorest, voted on equal terms exactly as in a modern democracy
- (B) All decisions were taken by the single richest individual in the state
- (C) Major decisions were shared among the heads of many leading families rather than resting with one hereditary king, but not every individual had an equal vote
- (D) The decisions were made entirely by foreign rulers from outside the state

26. Compare a monarchy like Magadha with a gana/sangha like Vajji. Which statement names the KEY governance difference, and avoids the false contrasts?

- (A) Magadha practised farming whereas Vajji did not farm at all
- (B) Magadha had no army while Vajji maintained a large one
- (C) Vajji used iron tools while Magadha relied only on bronze
- (D) In Magadha one hereditary rajaa held ultimate power, while in Vajji the assembly took the major decisions and chose the ruler

27. The statement 'a good rajaa was not supposed to rule by himself or do whatever he liked' best supports which conclusion about even monarchical states?

- (A) The rajaa in fact held no real power and the assemblies governed in his place
- (B) The people elected a new rajaa every year to keep him in check
- (C) There was no army at all to back up the rajaa's authority
- (D) Even a king was expected to take counsel from the assemblies and ministers rather than govern by personal whim

28. Taxation became a regular feature of the mahaajanapadas. What does the chapter give as the most important reason a state needed to collect taxes?

- (A) To replace farming so that no one in the state needed to grow food
- (B) To pay for the armies, fortifications and administration that the ruler maintained
- (C) To discourage trade between neighbouring regions
- (D) To abolish the need for any kind of ruler

29. The presence of ramparts, regular taxation and standing armies in the mahaajanapadas is taken by the chapter as a sign of what?

- (A) They were loose bands of wanderers with no fixed authority
- (B) They were purely religious settlements with no government of any kind
- (C) They were exact reconstructions of the earlier Harappan cities
- (D) They were organised states whose rulers could gather and direct resources and defence

30. Contrast the metal expertise of the First Urbanisation with the technological key to the Second. Which statement is correct?

- (A) The Harappans used iron, while the second wave returned to bronze
- (B) Both waves depended chiefly on gold tools

- (C) The Harappans used iron coins, while the second wave used silver tools
- (D) The Harappans mastered copper and bronze, while the Second Urbanisation was driven by the spread of iron

31. Why does the chapter treat iron as more important for state-building than gold or silver could be?

- (A) Iron was worshipped as sacred, so people gathered into cities to honour it
- (B) Iron removed any further need for trade routes between regions
- (C) Iron was used to print the first books, which spread knowledge and built states
- (D) Iron axes and ploughs cleared forests and worked heavy soil, raising the food surpluses that fed cities and armies

32. A farmer in a Ganga-plains janapada switches from a wooden digging stick to an iron-tipped plough. Which chain of consequences would the chapter predict?

- (A) Heavier soil can be worked, harvests rise, the surplus feeds non-farmers, and towns can grow
- (B) Harvests fall, so people abandon the land and cities shrink
- (C) Trade routes close because food no longer needs to be moved
- (D) The need for any ruler or for taxes simply disappears

33. A historian says iron was NECESSARY for the Second Urbanisation but not by itself SUFFICIENT. Which observation best illustrates the 'not sufficient' part?

- (A) Iron alone, with nothing else, instantly produced great cities everywhere it appeared
- (B) Iron was never actually used in the Ganga plains at all
- (C) Cities had appeared long before iron and so never needed it
- (D) Iron also had to combine with fertile soil, trade routes and organised rulers before cities and states could actually grow

34. How does the chapter connect stronger, iron-equipped armies to the wider political map of the period?

- (A) Stronger armies caused warfare to disappear completely across the plains
- (B) Stronger armies brought farming to an end as soldiers replaced farmers
- (C) Stronger armies led directly to the first invention of writing
- (D) Better-armed states could defeat and absorb their neighbours, so kingdoms grew larger, a step toward the first empires

35. Suppose iron metallurgy had NEVER spread in ancient India. Based on the chapter's reasoning, what is the most likely outcome?

- (A) Clearing forests and ploughing heavy soil would have been far harder, so the Second Urbanisation would have been much weaker
- (B) Cities would have grown even faster than they actually did

- (C) The Harappan civilisation would never have ended
- (D) Coins would have been invented far sooner than they were

36. A student claims, 'The long gap between the two urbanisations proves cities once lost can never return.' How does the chapter's evidence best refute this?

- (A) The Harappan cities were in fact never abandoned at all
- (B) Cities did return, since a wholly new urban wave rose in the Ganga plains after the long non-urban gap
- (C) There was actually no gap at all between the two waves
- (D) Cities have existed continuously since the Stone Age, so none were ever lost

37. A jaati is best described as which of the following?

- (A) A deep, water-filled ditch dug to defend a city
- (B) A long-distance highway used for trade and pilgrimage
- (C) An occupational community whose skills and customs were passed from parents to children
- (D) A silver coin stamped with several symbols

38. Within the four-fold varna scheme, which pairing of a varna with its expected role is correct?

- (A) Brahmins were expected to defend the land in battle
- (B) Kshatriyas were expected to defend society and the land and to wage war when necessary
- (C) Vaishyas were expected to perform rituals and preserve knowledge
- (D) Shudras were expected to rule the kingdom as warriors

39. A student says, 'The varna-jaati system was rigid and unchanging from its very first day.' How does the chapter correct this?

- (A) The system never actually existed in this period at all
- (B) The system applied only to the Harappan cities
- (C) The system became completely rigid on the very day it began
- (D) In the early period the system was more flexible, and people could change occupations as circumstances required

40. Two great routes connected India's regions. Which statement matches each route to its direction correctly?

- (A) The Uttaraapatha ran toward the south, while the Dakshinaapatha was the northern route
- (B) The Uttaraapatha was the northern route, while the Dakshinaapatha ran toward the south
- (C) Both routes ran only east to west along the coast
- (D) Both routes lay entirely inside a single mahaajanapada

41. The Dakshinaapatha began near today's Prayagraj, at Kaushambi, and then crossed a particular range to reach the south. Which range was it?

- (A) The Himalayas
- (B) The Aravalli Range
- (C) The Vindhya Range
- (D) The Western Ghats

42. Beyond goods, what did the two great trade routes also carry that helped knit the Subcontinent together?

- (A) Only the rajaa's private letters and nothing else
- (B) Pilgrims, armies, ideas and coins moving between regions
- (C) Only soldiers, with no other traffic
- (D) Only iron ore, and never any people

43. Around 400 BCE, three kingdoms emerged in the southern part of the Subcontinent. Which set names them?

- (A) Magadha, Kosala and Avanti
- (B) The Cholas, Cheras and Pandyas
- (C) Vajji, Malla and Anga
- (D) Kuru, Panchaala and Matsya

44. Why did the south become drawn into trade with the rest of the Subcontinent?

- (A) It had an unusually cold climate that attracted traders
- (B) It had no rivers at all, which made overland travel simpler
- (C) It lay far from the sea, so it needed to import everything by land
- (D) It held valuable resources such as gems, gold and spices that other regions wanted

45. By about 300-200 BCE, how does the chapter describe the state of the Subcontinent?

- (A) Completely emptied of people once again
- (B) One vibrant, interconnected land whose goods and culture even reached beyond India
- (C) Split into three separate islands
- (D) Ruled once more entirely by the Harappans

46. Around the time India became one interconnected land, what became of the mahaajanapadas?

- (A) They were only just being founded for the very first time
- (B) They came to an end, clearing the way for the first great empires
- (C) They all converted into ganas or sanghas
- (D) They relocated westward into the Indus valley

47. Magadha, in today's Bihar, became one of the most powerful mahaajanapadas. Following the chapter's logic, what is the single best reason?

- (A) It sat on the fertile middle Ganga plain with food surpluses, river transport and nearby resources
- (B) It had no rivers, which made it naturally easy to defend
- (C) It was a gana or sangha that elected its rulers
- (D) It lay far to the south near the Pandyas

48. Which statement best captures why the Ganga plains, rather than the old Indus region, became the heartland of the Second Urbanisation?

- (A) The Harappans simply rebuilt their old Indus cities exactly as before
- (B) The Ganga plains had no farming, so people gathered there only for safety
- (C) The new mix of fertile soil, iron, surplus farming and connecting routes came together in the Ganga plains, where the second wave of cities and states then arose
- (D) Iron was unknown in the Ganga plains, forcing a reliance on bronze

49. Why does the chapter present the rise of cities, the growth of states and the appearance of coins as ONE connected story rather than three unrelated events?

- (A) They happened in three different millennia with no link between them
- (B) Surplus farming fed cities and states, the growing trade required coins, and each development reinforced the others
- (C) Coins appeared first and only later caused any farming to begin
- (D) Each of the three unfolded on a separate continent

50. If a region had fertile soil and iron but lay completely off all the trade routes, what does the chapter's reasoning suggest about its prospects as a great state?

- (A) Stronger, because isolation always protects a state from harm
- (B) Unchanged, because trade played no role at all in the growth of states
- (C) Guaranteed to become the largest empire of the age
- (D) Weaker, because without trade links it would miss the exchange of goods, coins and ideas that helped states flourish

51. Shishupalgarh, an eastern city with a neat square plan and strong fortifications, was the capital associated with which region?

- (A) Magadha
- (B) Kalinga
- (C) Gandhara
- (D) Avanti

52. Which chain of cause and effect from the chapter is correctly ordered?

- (A) Coins were invented, then barter began, then trade stopped
- (B) Cities grew, then forests reappeared, then iron vanished
- (C) Empires formed, then janapadas appeared, then clans settled
- (D) Iron spread, then more farmland was cleared, then food surpluses grew, then cities and states grew

53. Someone claims, 'The Second Urbanisation has never really stopped; it continues to this day.' Which fact best backs this up?

- (A) Several mahaajanapada capitals, such as Varanasi, are still living cities about 2,500 years later
- (B) All the Harappan cities are still inhabited today
- (C) Iron tools have completely fallen out of use
- (D) Barter is still India's main form of trade

54. A teacher writes the timeline note 'janapadas merge into mahaajanapadas.' Reasoning about WHY this merging happened, which explanation fits the chapter best?

- (A) The Harappans returned and combined the janapadas for them
- (B) All janapadas peacefully dissolved because no one wanted land any more
- (C) Stronger janapadas absorbed weaker neighbours through war and alliance, helped by iron weapons and growing wealth, forming larger states
- (D) Foreign empires arrived first and split big states into janapadas

55. A historian wishes to demonstrate that the mahaajanapadas were organised STATES rather than mere settlements. Which single combination of evidence would best serve that argument?

- (A) Undeciphered Harappan seals, standardised weights, and planned drainage
- (B) The complete absence of any rulers, assemblies or coins
- (C) Cowrie-shell exchange, with no walls, no taxes and no army
- (D) Fortified capitals, regular collection of taxes, and the maintenance of standing armies

56. A coin found far from its mint and a 2,500-year-old capital still inhabited today are cited as evidence for two different chapter claims. Which pairing correctly matches each find to the claim it supports?

- (A) The travelled coin supports the continuity of the Second Urbanisation; the still-living capital supports long-distance trade
- (B) Both finds together prove that the Harappans founded the Ganga-plains cities
- (C) Both finds together prove that barter never gave way to coined money
- (D) The travelled coin supports long-distance trade along the routes; the still-living capital supports the continuity of the Second Urbanisation

57. A student says, 'Because the gana/sangha assemblies chose their rulers, they were exactly the same as a modern democracy.' Which correction is most accurate?

- (A) They were broader than a monarchy since many family heads decided together, but narrower than a modern democracy because not every individual had an equal vote
- (B) Correct, since every adult in a gana or sangha voted equally just as in a modern democracy
- (C) Wrong, because the gana/sangha rulers actually inherited power by birth like kings
- (D) Wrong, because the gana/sangha assemblies in fact took no decisions at all

58. A label reads, 'In the mahaajanapada age, the monarch ruled entirely alone and answered to no one.' Why does the chapter contradict this?

- (A) Because monarchies did not exist in the mahaajanapada age at all
- (B) Even a hereditary king was expected to take counsel from assemblies such as the sabhaa and samiti and from his ministers rather than rule by his own whim

- (C) Because the assemblies, not the king, governed every monarchy directly
- (D) Because the people elected and removed the monarch each year

59. A student arranges the deeper causes behind the Second Urbanisation as a chain. Which ordering best matches the chapter's reasoning, with the most basic enabling condition first?

- (A) Growing trade needing coins, then spread of iron, then larger cities, then more land cleared, then larger food surpluses
- (B) Larger cities and states, then larger food surpluses, then spread of iron, then more land cleared, then growing trade
- (C) Spread of iron, then more land cleared and heavier soil ploughed, then larger food surpluses, then growing trade needing coins, then larger cities and states
- (D) Larger food surpluses, then spread of iron, then growing trade, then more land cleared, then larger cities

60. Why is the spread of iron treated as part of what distinguishes the SECOND Urbanisation from the FIRST, rather than as a shared feature of both?

- (A) Iron came into general use only in the later Ganga-plains phase, whereas the Harappans of the First Urbanisation worked copper and bronze, not iron
- (B) Iron was used heavily by the Harappans but abandoned in the second wave, which returned to bronze
- (C) Both waves relied on iron equally, so it cannot distinguish them at all
- (D) Iron was used only for minting coins in both periods, so it tells the two waves apart by their money

Solutions — Social Science (Class 7), Chapter 4: New Beginnings: Cities and States — Paper 4

Paper 4 — (progressively harder)

Marking: +4 correct, –1 wrong, 0 unattempted. Maximum marks **240**.

Answer Key

Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans
1	C	11	A	21	C	31	D	41	C	51	B
2	C	12	D	22	A	32	A	42	B	52	D
3	A	13	B	23	C	33	D	43	B	53	A
4	A	14	A	24	A	34	D	44	D	54	C
5	A	15	A	25	C	35	A	45	B	55	D
6	C	16	C	26	D	36	B	46	B	56	D
7	B	17	C	27	D	37	C	47	A	57	A
8	A	18	C	28	B	38	B	48	C	58	B
9	B	19	B	29	D	39	D	49	B	59	C
10	C	20	D	30	D	40	B	50	D	60	A

Answer-key distribution: A = 15, B = 15, C = 15, D = 15.

Worked Solutions

1. (C) The Harappan (First Urbanisation) order is earliest; iron became widespread only much later in the Ganga-plains phase; that iron-fed surplus helped janapadas merge into the larger mahaajanapadas; and the mahaajanapadas finally gave way to the first empires. The option that puts iron before the Harappans reverses the two urbanisations. The option placing empires before iron and the merging puts the last stage in the middle. The option starting with the merging puts the larger states before the Harappans and before the iron that made them possible.

2. (C) 'Revival' would wrongly imply continuity of people, place and features; in fact the second wave was a later, independent rise in a new region marked by iron and punch-marked coins. The option about reusing Harappan citadels and script is false: the new cities were elsewhere and did not carry on the Harappan script. The 'only a few decades apart' option is wrong because roughly a thousand non-urban years separated the two. The 'Harappans moved east' option invents a migration the chapter does not describe and contradicts the long gap.

3. (A) The claim is that the whole working system, not just walls, was lost; it would be undermined only if trade, writing and administration had actually continued. The 'people went back to village life and trade and writing faded' option supports the claim rather than undermining it. The 'thousand-year gap before cities returned' option also supports a loss of urban order. The 'new cities used iron and coins' option is about the later wave's novelty and says nothing against the loss of the earlier order.

4. (A) Two independent lines agreeing is convincing because they are unlikely to share the same mistake, so the converging picture is sturdier. The 'texts record exact spoken words, so texts alone are decisive' option overstates what texts give and dismisses archaeology. The 'texts are always wrong' option falsely discards one whole source. The last option is impossible: the Harappan First-Urbanisation people did not write the later texts, whose script is undeciphered, and they did not excavate later sites.

5. (A) 'Where the people set foot' signals a community that settled and tied itself to a fixed land, the very change that made early states possible. The 'army on the march' option contradicts the whole point, which is settling down rather than moving. The 'coin' option confuses a word for a territory with money. The 'sprawling empire' option overshoots the scale: a janapada was a single clan's home territory, not an empire.

6. (C) The chapter's criteria are settled population, fixed territory and an organising authority, and janapadas met all three under a rajaa, so size does not disqualify them. The 'must rule many regions' option imposes an empire-sized test the chapter never sets. The 'no leader at all' option is false, since a rajaa led the janapada. The 'iron coins from the start' option is an anachronism, as coins (silver punch-marked) belong to a later stage, not the origin of janapadas.

7. (B) The prefix 'maha-' (great) marks scale: mahaajanapadas were the bigger states into which earlier janapadas merged, so the two terms differ in size and stage. The 'coin and route' option misidentifies both words entirely. The 'mahaajanapada came first and broke apart' option reverses the direction of change, which ran from small to large. The 'always a republic vs always a monarchy' option is false, since both monarchies and ganas/sanghas existed among the mahaajanapadas and that is not what the prefix marks.

8. (A) The chapter credits fertile soil, available iron and connecting rivers and routes; a cold, dry, riverless plain is the opposite of what it describes, since rivers were a key advantage, so that option is the odd one out. Fertile soil with surpluses is a genuine reason. Access to iron is a genuine reason. Rivers and trade routes linking the region is a genuine reason.

9. (B) Sixteen is a useful traditional grouping from the textual tradition, not a precise modern headcount, so a little caution is fair. The 'certainly one hundred' option asserts a precise number the chapter never gives. The 'never existed' option denies real, well-

attested states. The 'compiled by the Harappans' option is impossible, since the Harappans vanished long before the mahaajanapadas and their lists.

10. (C) The sixteen were many distinct, sizeable states existing around the same time and spread over a broad region. The 'sixteen successive empires' option turns contemporaries into a sequence. The 'small villages in one valley' option shrinks states into a hamlet cluster. The 'names for one kingdom' option collapses many states into a single one, which the wide geographic span (Gandhaara to Anga) contradicts.

11. (A) Walls, a water-filled ditch and a pinch-point gate form a coherent defence-and-control package, exactly what a rich state with rivals would build. The 'beautiful for festivals' option ignores that all three are defensive. The 'store rainwater' option is contradicted by the rampart and narrow gate, which are not water tanks. The 'wander in freely' option is directly contradicted by the narrow gate, whose purpose is to restrict movement.

12. (D) Narrowing the gate concentrates movement at one controllable point, letting few guards watch, inspect and even collect tolls. The 'rainwater drains faster' option confuses a gateway with a drain. The 'two elephants side by side' option would require a wide gate, the opposite of narrow. The 'look graceful' option treats a security feature as mere decoration.

13. (B) Continuous occupation for 2,500 years points to enduring advantages of site, such as fertile surroundings, river access and trade position. The 'nothing has changed' option mistakes continuity for being frozen in time. The 'founded by the Harappans' option is wrong, since these were Second-Urbanisation capitals, not Harappan ones. The 'never fortified' option contradicts the chapter, which describes these capitals as ramparted and moated.

14. (A) Punch-marked coins appeared in the later Ganga-plains wave; the Harappans had no coinage at all, so dating a coin to their period is the error. The 'only gold coins' option is false, since the Harappans used no coins of any metal. The 'never used anywhere in ancient India' option is false, since coins were used, just later. The 'made of iron' option misnames the metal, as punch-marked coins were silver.

15. (A) A medium of exchange exists to ease buying and selling, so its widespread use signals expanding commerce beyond barter's reach. The 'jewellery' option ignores their role as money. The 'buried with the dead' option reduces a trade tool to a grave good. The 'made barter more popular' option is self-contradictory, since coins mark a move away from barter, not toward it.

16. (C) Coins drifting far from home is the natural signature of long-distance trade carrying them along the routes, and one cause explains both finds. The 'made on the spot' option contradicts the coins being identified with distant regions. The 'one identical coin'

option is false, since regions usually struck their own coins, which is why these can be traced to Avanti and Anga. The 'forbidden to leave' option would make such finds impossible.

17. (C) The double difficulty of matching wants is what makes barter clumsy, and a common coin neatly removes it. The 'only after sunset' option invents a time restriction barter never had. The 'bank in every village' option is anachronistic, since barter predates banks. The 'needs iron tools' option falsely links swapping goods to a particular technology.

18. (C) Although each region usually made its own coins, neighbouring coins also circulated and travelled along trade routes, even abroad. The 'never accepted another region's coins' option contradicts the finds of foreign coins. The 'only the Harappans minted' option is impossible, since coins postdate the Harappans entirely. The 'banned outside the capital' option contradicts the cross-regional circulation the chapter describes.

19. (B) 'Hereditary' means power is inherited by birth, so the throne usually went to the king's son or kin, the very thing that distinguishes a monarchy from a gana/sangha. The 'assembly voted each time' option describes a republic, not a hereditary monarchy. The 'wealthiest merchant' option ignores birth as the basis of succession. The 'foreign conqueror inherits' option confuses conquest with inheritance.

20. (D) A monarch's duties included keeping order, collecting revenue, and maintaining defence; succession was hereditary, not decided by public election, so the election option is the duty that does not belong. Keeping law and order is a genuine duty. Collecting taxes is a genuine duty. Maintaining an army and fortifications is a genuine duty.

21. (C) In a monarchy the king held power yet was supposed to govern with the advice of the sabha and samiti and his ministers, sharing counsel but not rule. The 'assemblies governed directly, king a figurehead' option describes a republic, not a monarchy. The 'ignored entirely' option erases the advisory role the chapter affirms. The 'fresh king every year by vote' option contradicts hereditary kingship.

22. (A) Older Vedic words for assemblies alongside later republican terms point to a continuous, evolving tradition of shared decision-making. The 'Vedas composed after the mahaajanapadas' option reverses the time order the layering implies. The 'no earlier roots' option ignores that the Vedic terms show exactly such roots. The 'gana and sangha mean a hereditary king' option is backwards, since those terms describe republics, the opposite of hereditary kingship.

23. (C) In a gana/sangha the assembly chose the ruler by debate and, if necessary, a vote, and that locus of decision is the defining republican trait. The 'eldest son always inherited' option describes a monarchy, not a republic. The 'Harappan priests appointed' option is

impossible, since the Harappans were long gone. The 'foreign empire imposed' option misdescribes how these early republics chose their leaders.

24. (A) The accurate picture is a majority of monarchies plus at least two republics, Vajji and Malla, so the blanket claim fails. The 'entirely correct, no exceptions' option ignores those two republics. The 'none ever had a king' option swings to the opposite error, since most did have kings. The 'only the southern ones had kings' option adds a geographic qualifier the chapter never makes.

25. (C) These republics spread decision-making across many family and clan heads, broader than one king's will yet short of universal suffrage. The 'every adult voted equally' option overstates inclusion into a modern democracy. The 'single richest individual decided' option narrows power to one person, contradicting shared decision-making. The 'foreign rulers decided' option removes self-rule entirely, which is the opposite of a republic.

26. (D) The essential contrast is WHO decides: a single inheriting king versus a decision-making assembly that also picks the ruler. The 'farming vs no farming' option is false, since both relied on farming. The 'no army vs large army' option is false, since both maintained armies. The 'iron vs bronze' option is false, since both belonged to the iron age, so only the locus of political power genuinely separates them.

27. (D) The line shows the king governed WITH advice, not that he was powerless or replaceable yearly. The 'no real power, assemblies governed' option overshoots into a republic. The 'elected every year' option contradicts hereditary kingship. The 'no army at all' option is unrelated to the point and contradicts the monarch's duty of maintaining an army.

28. (B) Taxes funded the costly running of a state: soldiers, walls and officials. The 'replace farming' option is false, since taxes were often levied on farm produce rather than replacing it. The 'discourage trade' option is false, since states benefited from trade. The 'abolish the need for a ruler' option is self-contradictory, since collecting revenue is itself one of the ruler's functions.

29. (D) Walls, tax collection and armies require an authority able to mobilise resources, the hallmark of organised states. The 'loose bands of wanderers' option contradicts the fixed, organised authority such features imply. The 'purely religious settlements with no government' option ignores the very governing apparatus described. The 'reconstructions of Harappan cities' option is false, since these were new Ganga-age states, not copies of the long-collapsed Harappan order.

30. (D) The First Urbanisation worked copper and bronze; iron became widespread only in the later Ganga-plains wave, which it powered. The 'Harappans used iron, second wave bronze' option reverses the two. The 'both depended on gold tools' option is false for both

waves. The 'Harappan iron coins' option is doubly wrong, since the Harappans had no coins and did not work iron.

31. (D) Iron's value was practical and agricultural: tougher tools opened heavy, forested land and lifted harvests that supported non-farmers and soldiers. The 'worshipped as sacred' option treats a working metal as a cult object. The 'removed the need for trade routes' option is false, since trade in fact grew. The 'printed the first books' option is anachronistic and unrelated to iron's role.

32. (A) An iron plough breaks tougher soil and grows more, generating the surplus that supports town-dwellers, the engine of urban growth. The 'harvests fall' option reverses the expected effect. The 'trade routes close' option is wrong, since more surplus means more, not less, trade. The 'need for rulers and taxes disappears' option is wrong, since a larger settled population needs administration more, not less.

33. (D) 'Necessary but not sufficient' means iron was required yet had to act together with soil, routes and rulers to yield cities. The 'iron alone instantly produced cities' option claims sufficiency, the opposite point. The 'never used in the Ganga plains' option denies iron's necessity. The 'cities appeared before iron' option contradicts the chapter's sequence, in which iron came first and enabled the growth.

34. (D) Iron weapons made armies more effective, which helped powerful states conquer and merge rivals into larger kingdoms. The 'warfare disappeared' option is the opposite of what stronger armies imply. The 'farming ended' option is false, since farming expanded with iron ploughs. The 'led to writing' option links two unrelated developments.

35. (A) Since iron tools enabled the land-clearing and farming behind the surplus, removing iron would have starved that surplus and weakened the urban wave. The 'cities grew even faster' option contradicts iron's enabling role. The 'Harappan civilisation never ended' option is irrelevant, since its collapse happened long before and for other reasons. The 'coins invented sooner' option is unsupported, since the money economy rested on the trade that iron-fed growth made possible.

36. (B) The Second Urbanisation itself disproves the claim, since after about a thousand non-urban years city life reappeared in a new region. The 'never abandoned' option is false, since the Harappan cities were indeed lost. The 'no gap at all' option denies the well-attested gap. The 'cities since the Stone Age' option overstates continuity and ignores the documented break.

37. (C) A jaati was a community defined by occupation, with skills and customs handed down within families. The 'water-filled ditch' option describes a moat, not a social group. The 'long-distance highway' option describes a patha, a trade route. The 'silver coin' option describes a punch-marked coin, not a community.

38. (B) Kshatriyas were the varna associated with protection and warfare. The 'Brahmins defend in battle' option swaps roles, since Brahmins were linked with knowledge and rituals. The 'Vaishyas perform rituals' option is wrong, since Vaishyas were linked with trade and agriculture. The 'Shudras rule as warriors' option is wrong, since Shudras were linked with service occupations.

39. (D) The chapter stresses that in this early phase movement between occupations was possible, so it was not fixed from the start. The 'never existed' option denies a system the chapter does describe. The 'only the Harappan cities' option is wrong, since it belongs to the later Ganga-plains age. The 'rigid on the very day it began' option restates the misconception rather than correcting it.

40. (B) 'Uttara' means north and 'dakshina' means south, so the names themselves fix the directions: Uttaraapatha north, Dakshinaapatha south. The first distractor reverses the two. The 'only east to west along the coast' option misdescribes routes that ran broadly north and south. The 'inside a single mahaajanapada' option shrinks routes that spanned many regions into one state.

41. (C) To pass from the northern plains into the peninsula, the southern route crossed the Vindhyas, the dividing range between north and south India. The Himalayas lie far to the north, the wrong direction for a route heading south. The Aravallis run through the northwest, off the southward path. The Western Ghats edge the western coast and are not the range a route from Kaushambi southward would first cross.

42. (B) The routes were arteries for people and ideas as well as merchandise: pilgrims, armies, beliefs and coins all travelled along them. The 'only royal letters' option is far too narrow. The 'only soldiers' option ignores pilgrims, ideas and coins. The 'only iron ore, never people' option contradicts the very mixing of people and ideas that helped unify the regions.

43. (B) The southern trio were the Cholas, Cheras and Pandyas. Magadha, Kosala and Avanti were powerful northern mahaajanapadas. Vajji, Malla and Anga lay in the north and east. Kuru, Panchaala and Matsya were northern janapadas/mahaajanapadas, so only the Chola-Chera-Pandya set is southern.

44. (D) The south's prized resources, gems, gold and spices, pulled it into the wider trade networks. The 'cold climate' option is neither accurate nor a draw for trade. The 'no rivers, easier travel' option is wrong, since the absence of rivers would hinder movement. The 'far from the sea' option is false, since the south's coastal position actually aided maritime trade.

45. (B) By this date trade, coins and ideas had linked the regions into a single connected land, with influence spilling beyond India's borders. The 'emptied of people' option contradicts the bustling, connected picture. The 'three separate islands' option is

geographically false. The 'ruled by the Harappans again' option is impossible, since the Harappan civilisation had ended roughly a thousand years earlier.

46. (B) As the land integrated, the mahaajanapadas gave way to the early empires, the next, larger stage of state formation. The 'just being founded' option puts their beginning where their end belongs. The 'all became republics' option is false, since their era was ending, not transforming wholesale. The 'relocated into the Indus valley' option invents a migration the chapter does not describe.

47. (A) Magadha's strength flowed from its fertile Ganga location, rich harvests, river routes and access to resources such as iron, the very ingredients the chapter ties to powerful states. The 'no rivers' option is wrong, since rivers were an asset, not a defensive gap. The 'gana/sangha that elected rulers' option misclassifies Magadha, a monarchy. The 'far to the south near the Pandyas' option misplaces a northern state.

48. (C) The second wave took root where its enabling conditions converged: the fertile, iron-rich, route-linked Ganga plains, not the long-collapsed Indus cities. The 'rebuilt the Indus cities' option ignores the new region. The 'no farming' option is false, since the plains were intensely farmed. The 'iron unknown' option is false, since iron was central to the Ganga-plains wave.

49. (B) The developments are interlinked: agricultural surplus underpinned cities and states, the resulting trade called for coins, and each fed back into the others as a single web of cause and effect. The 'three different millennia' option separates roughly contemporary events. The 'coins first, then farming' option reverses the order, since surplus farming preceded and enabled coins. The 'separate continent' option is plainly false, since all unfolded in the same land.

50. (D) Fertile soil and iron give surplus, but the chapter ties powerful states to connectivity as well; cut off from routes, a region would lose the exchange of goods, coins and ideas. The 'isolation always protects' option treats being cut off as an advantage the chapter does not grant. The 'trade played no role' option contradicts the chapter's emphasis on connectivity. The 'guaranteed largest empire' option overclaims from soil and iron alone.

51. (B) Shishupalgarh, in the east with its square fortified plan, was the capital associated with Kalinga. Magadha, in Bihar, had capitals such as Rajagriha, not an eastern square-planned site. Gandhaara lay in the far northwest. Avanti lay in central-western India, none of which matches an eastern, square-planned city.

52. (D) The driving sequence runs from iron, to cleared land, to surplus food, to cities and states, each step enabling the next. The 'coins, then barter, then trade stopped' option reverses the relationship, since barter came first and coins helped trade grow. The 'cities grew, forests reappeared, iron vanished' option runs the consequences backwards. The

'empires, then janapadas, then clans settled' option inverts the whole order, since clans settled first and empires came last.

53. (A) The clearest support is that Second-Urbanisation cities like Varanasi remain alive and busy after roughly 2,500 years, an unbroken thread. The 'Harappan cities still inhabited' option is false and concerns the First Urbanisation. The 'iron fallen out of use' option is false. The 'barter still the main trade' option is false, so none of these supports the claim.

54. (C) Larger states formed as more powerful janapadas, backed by iron arms and surplus wealth, defeated or absorbed weaker ones. The 'Harappans returned' option is impossible, since they had long since vanished. The 'no one wanted land any more' option contradicts clans' strong ties to their territory. The 'foreign empires split states into janapadas' option reverses the direction, which ran from small units to large.

55. (D) Walls, taxation and armies together require an authority able to gather and direct resources, which is exactly what marks an organised state. The 'Harappan seals, weights, drainage' option points to the earlier First Urbanisation, not these states. The 'absence of rulers, assemblies or coins' option would argue against statehood, not for it. The 'cowrie exchange with no walls, taxes or army' option lacks every feature that signals an organised state.

56. (D) A coin drifting far from its mint is the signature of trade carrying it along routes, while a capital alive after 2,500 years shows the second wave's unbroken continuity, so each find supports its own claim. The first distractor swaps the two matches. The 'Harappans founded the Ganga cities' option is false, since those cities were not Harappan. The 'barter never gave way to coins' option contradicts the rise of coined money the travelled coin itself reflects.

57. (A) These early republics shared decisions among many leading-family heads, broader than one king's will yet short of universal suffrage, so 'early' not 'modern' is right. The 'every adult voted equally' option overstates inclusion. The 'rulers inherited by birth' option is false, since the assembly chose them, which is what makes them republics. The 'assemblies took no decisions' option contradicts their defining feature.

58. (B) The chapter stresses that a good rajaa governed with the counsel of the assemblies and ministers, not by himself, so 'ruled entirely alone' is wrong. The 'monarchies did not exist' option is false, since most mahaajanapadas were monarchies. The 'assemblies governed directly' option describes a republic, not a monarchy. The 'elected and removed each year' option contradicts hereditary kingship.

59. (C) The chapter's logic begins with iron, which let people clear land and work heavy soil, producing surpluses that fed cities and supported trade needing coins, and so cities and states grew. The first distractor puts trade and coins before the iron that ultimately

made them possible. The second puts cities before the iron and surplus that built them, reversing the chain. The third places surplus before the iron that produced it, breaking the causal order.

60. (A) Iron became widespread only in the second wave; the Harappans worked copper and bronze, so iron marks the later phase, not a shared feature. The 'Harappans used iron, abandoned later' option reverses the truth. The 'both relied on iron equally' option is false, since the First Urbanisation did not use iron. The 'iron only for coins' option is wrong, since coins were silver, not iron, and were a Second-Urbanisation development.